

MUMBAI | Out of the Box



A DABBAWALA AT WORK

SOURIK KAR/www.indiatodayimages.com

The famous dabbawalas of Mumbai are said to be part of the curriculum of the prestigious Harvard Business School (HBS). But wait. The study is supposed to be weeks away from publication and the dabbawalas say they have not even contributed to the detailed study. Association President Raghunath Medge, who represents 5,000 dabbawalas delivering two lakh tiffins every day, says, "HBS has not approached us, so how can they do a case study? I wish someone had." HBS spokesperson Cullen Schmitt said the report would be ready in two weeks. The dabbawalas are already part of case studies at many business schools and have been visited by Prince Charles and Richard Branson. The Harvard B-School study would have been a coup of sorts, had the two groups spoken.

by Nishika Patel

MUMBAI | Baby Blues

Even as the number of people willing to adopt a child has increased, there has been a fall in number of babies received by the Child Welfare Committee (cwc). The number of abandoned babies in 2009 was 65, down from 77 in 2008 and 96 in 2006. Citing examples of newborns being kidnapped from hospitals, cwc Chairman Dr Shaila Mhatre says the long and tedious process involved in adoption makes several turn to illegal means for obtaining a child.

by Nishat Bari

KOLKATA | Past Forward

THE BENGAL GOVERNMENT DOES A RUSH JOB WITH 18,000 PAGES OF TAGORE'S WORKS.

Rabindranath Tagore fans can now access the bard's poems, songs and short stories with just a click. The Society of Natural Language Research has developed a website that contains 18,000 pages of Tagore's works. Pabitra Sarkar, educationist and adviser of the project, said, "We intend to put everything there by April to time with Tagore's 150th birth anniversary." A glance at some of the short stories on the state-funded website indicate a rush job by the Government; the translations are well below average and the titles seem literal English makeovers.

by Abhijit Dasgupta

MIG-29Ks WILL SOON JOIN THE NAVY. THE ONLY HITCH: THERE ARE NO CARRIERS.

DELHI | On the Deck

Next week, the Indian Navy is to commission the first four of its Russian-built MiG-29K carrier-borne naval fighter aircraft. There's only one hitch though: there's no aircraft carrier. The refit of the *Vikramaditya* (formerly the *Admiral Gorshkov*) for which the 16 aircraft were contracted in 2004 for \$500 million has been delayed by over three years and will now join the navy only in 2013. There's a small consolation though: a mockup called the Shore Based Test Facility—only the third one of its kind in the world which simulates the deck of the aircraft carrier—is taking shape ashore at Goa's Dabolim airbase. The pilots can at least practice take-offs and landings on the concrete for the next three years.

by Sandeep Unnithan

